



R. V. MOORTHY

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With the scheduling of the upcoming IPL facing logistical challenges due to the impending Lok Sabha elections and the T20 World Cup in June, the league could see a greater number of double-headers as the organisers are keen on wrapping up the tournament by May 25 or 26. The T20 World Cup begins on June 1, and the BCCI would want to give its players time to prepare for conditions in the U.S. and West Indies, chairman of the IPL Governing Council Arun Dhumal (**above**) said. He is also confident of holding the entirety of the tournament in India, retaining the home-and-away format.



AP

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New Zealand's 31-year wait for a Test win against Trans-Tasman rival Australia continued as skipper Pat Cummins and Alex Carey's 81-run stand for the eighth wicket sealed the visitor's three-wicket win in the second Test in Christchurch. The Black Caps, celebrating stalwarts Kane Williamson and Tim Southee's 100th appearance in the longest format, failed to mark the occasion with what would have been a famous win and succumbed to a series sweep after having Australia in dire straits (80/5) while chasing 279. Nathan Lyon's 10-wicket haul had spun Australia to a 172-run win in the opening Test.



CRICKET IRELAND

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Ireland created history by claiming its maiden Test win since becoming a Full Member in 2017. After a spell of seven consecutive defeats in the format, captain Andy Balbirnie took it upon himself to steer his team to a six-wicket victory against Afghanistan. The Irish skipper struck an unbeaten half-century, helping his side tide over the loss of four early wickets in a chase of 111. Pacer Mark Adair's eight-wicket haul was also crucial in Ireland surpassing the likes of South Africa (12), Sri Lanka (14), India (25) and New Zealand (45) in terms of the fewest matches taken for a first Test win.



AFP

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The BCCI introduced the 'Test Cricket Incentive Scheme' to provide additional financial rewards to India's men's Test cricketers. Now, a player who plays at least 75 per cent of India's Test matches in its annual cycle will earn Rs. 45 lakh per match in addition to the fixed match fee of Rs. 15 lakh. The players in the 50-75 per cent games bracket will earn a bonus of Rs. 30 lakh per game. The non-playing members of the squad will be paid half the amount. The move came days after the Board directed players to make themselves available for domestic tournaments to be eligible for national selection.



GETTY IMAGES

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Kolkata Knight Riders has named England's Phil Salt in its squad for the upcoming IPL season after fellow Englishman Jason Roy pulled out of the tournament due to personal reasons. Salt went unsold at the auction in December after representing Delhi Capitals in nine games last season. He had a scorching T20I series in the Caribbean last year, where he hammered back-to-back centuries and topped the run-scoring charts (331 runs). Roy, also an attacking top-order batter, previously pulled out of the IPL in 2020 and 2022.